

Information Sheet



Participant Information Sheet For Adult Participants

UCL Research Ethics Committee Approval ID Number: *CEHP/2024/596*

YOU WILL BE GIVEN A COPY OF THIS INFORMATION SHEET

Title of Study:

Decision-Making in a Dynamic Social Context

Department:

Psychology and Language Sciences (PaLS)

Name and Contact Details of the Researcher(s):

Timothy Sit (tim.sit.18@ucl.ac.uk)

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Name and Contact Details of the Principal Researcher:

Essi Viding (e.viding@ucl.ac.uk)

1. Invitation to take part

You are being invited to take part in a research project. Before you decide it is important for you to understand why the research is being done and what participation will involve.

Please take time to read the following information carefully and discuss it with others if you wish. Ask us if there is anything that is not clear or if you would like more information. Take time to decide whether you wish to take part. Thank you for reading this.

2. What is the project's purpose?

The aim of this project is to investigate how humans make decisions in a social environment, under motivation to maximise reward. Participants will play either (1) The arena game: a computer game in which they will be asked to navigate around an arena, claim rewards from highlighted walls of this arena, and decide upon the best rewards to prioritise in a multiplayer or single-player setting, or (2) The payoff matrix game: a computer game in which they will be asked to make multiple choices (eg. Left or right) in order to maximise reward in a multiplayer setting or against a computer opponent. By analysing participants' choices in this game in the context of reward-stimulus features and the information which the participant has access to, this project will uncover what strategies people use to determine how to act, interact, and maximise reward in a dynamic environment.

3. Why have I been chosen?

We are looking to study social decision making in the general population, in adults who are 18-60 years of age. All participants will be screened before participation and may be excluded if they have conditions that interfere with normal vision, manual action, and hand-eye coordination. Good vision or correction with contacts or eyeglasses is required. We will not ask for any prior medical history.

4. Do I have to take part?

It is up to you to decide whether to take part. If you do decide to take part, you will be given this information sheet to keep and be asked to sign an informed consent form. You can withdraw at any time without giving a reason and without it affecting any benefits that you are entitled to. If you decide to withdraw, you will be asked what you wish to happen to the data you have provided up to that point.

5. What will happen to me if I take part?

The entire game session will last up to 60 minutes, with breaks. You may be asked whether you would be comfortable in returning for a second session, and this will be discussed with you before beginning the experiment. The game consists of short blocks of events.

In the arena game, each event involves the presentation of an arena and a set of rewards and the event will conclude once the rewards have been reached by the players. You will only be required to control the movement of your avatar (via keyboard and mouse). Each typical event may take between 5-30 seconds. The design of this game includes multiple events presented in succession, with a short interval between them. Events may involve another player or include only you. Before the game begins, you will be given time to learn the controls, and how to move about the arena. At times specified through on-screen text you can pause for a break. A brief tutorial session will be shown first. This has the purpose of familiarising you with the controls of the game and introducing you progressively to the actions required to play the game. This period will also allow us to make sure you are comfortable to go ahead with the main body of the experiment.

In the pay-off matrix game, each event involves the selection of one of multiple choices, followed by feedback on the amount of reward obtained on that trial, and you will only be required to make the choices via keyboard or mouse input. A brief tutorial session will be provided at the beginning to familiarise you with the controls.

If at any time you feel tired or uncomfortable, you can stop immediately and let the researchers know. Data will be recorded about your actions within the game. [We will record your pupil diameter and gaze direction throughout the session using a pupillometer.] (for pupillometry experiments only).

At the beginning of the session, you may be asked to fill out a short open-ended questionnaire to assess your familiarity with video games. Following this, you may be provided with a small number of standardised trait questionnaires to assess how you display certain traits. At the end of the session, you will be provided with a debriefing information sheet concerning the purpose of the research and use of your data. Feel free to ask the

researchers any questions regarding the study. Please try to pay attention to each and every event.

6. What are the possible disadvantages and risks of taking part?

There are no risks associated with this testing procedure, which is purely behavioural. No assets within the game should lead to discomfort.

7. What are the possible benefits of taking part?

Whilst there are no direct benefits for participants in this project, you will be compensated for your time. The standard compensation for your time is a choice of £9 or 1.0 credit every hour. To help incentivise your effort to achieve a high level of reward, you will receive an additional amount (from a shared pool of £22 for competition between 2 players), conditional on your performance during the game. You should be aware that compensation above the standard rate is intended to motivate and reward your performance only. Perfect performance may not be feasible, and you should not feel expected to perform to a particular level.

8. Who to contact for questions and complaints?

For any further question or if you wish to report an issue, please contact the principal investigator Essi Viding (e.viding@ucl.ac.uk). If you have questions regarding your rights as a research subject, or if problems arise which you do not feel you can discuss with the Investigator, please contact the Chair of the UCL Research Ethics Committee – ethics@ucl.ac.uk.

9. Will my taking part in this project be kept confidential?

All the information that we collect about you during the course of the research will be kept strictly confidential. You will not be able to be identified in any ensuing reports or publications, wherein all data will be anonymised. Research records including your personal information will be stored securely in a locked cabinet and/or on password-protected computers. The research team will be the only party that will have access to your data.

10. Limits to confidentiality

Please note that assurances on confidentiality will be strictly adhered to unless evidence of wrongdoing or potential harm is uncovered. In such cases the University may be obliged to contact

relevant statutory bodies/agencies.

11. What will happen to the results of the research project?

We aim to publish the results of this research in the future. You will not be able to be identified in any ensuing reports or publications. The data collected will be additionally used to guide additional and subsequent research.

It is common practice to share pseudonymised data from research studies with the research community, so that other scientists can replicate and extend the analyses. It is up to you whether you are happy to make your pseudonymised data available for the broader research community. Not doing so will not preclude you from participating in this study. We will ask you separately whether you consent to this or not.

12. Local Data Protection Privacy Notice

Notice:

The controller for this project will be University College London (UCL). The UCL Data Protection Officer provides oversight of UCL activities involving the processing of personal data, and can be contacted at data-protection@ucl.ac.uk

This 'local' privacy notice sets out the information that applies to this particular study. Further information on how UCL uses participant information can be found in our 'general' privacy notice:

For participants in research studies, visit <https://www.ucl.ac.uk/legal-services/privacy/ucl-general-research-participant-privacy-notice>

The information that is required to be provided to participants under data protection legislation (GDPR and DPA 2018) is provided across both the 'local' and 'general' privacy notices.

The categories of personal data used will be as follows:

Name

Email Address

Gender

Date of Birth

The lawful basis that would be used to process your *personal data* will be performance of a task in the public interest. 

Your personal data will be processed so long as it is required for the research project (for up to 10 years after the completion of the study). If we are able to anonymise or pseudonymise the personal data you provide we will undertake this, and will endeavour to minimise the processing of personal data wherever possible.

If you are concerned about how your personal data is being processed, or if you would like to contact us about your rights, please contact UCL in the first instance at data-protection@ucl.ac.uk.

13. Who is organising and funding the research?

This study is organised and funded by the UCL Psychology and Language Sciences Division and UCL's Sainsbury Wellcome Centre for Neural Circuits and Behaviour.

16. Contact for further information

For further information, please contact the principal investigator (Essi Viding, e.viding@ucl.ac.uk) or the other researchers (Tom Hagley, tom.hagley.16@ucl.ac.uk; Ann Duan, c.duan@ucl.ac.uk).

You will be given a copy of this information sheet to keep and be asked to sign a consent form.

Thank you for reading this information sheet and for considering to take part in this research study.